



“Virtual volunteers can help NGOs not just technically—like choosing the Web server, scripting language, and database server—but also as advisors on how to gain best from the Internet”

Shalabh Sahai
Director
iVolunteer

proposals for grants from organisations—can be done at home (or office, boss permitting). Imagine this: you’re helping a blind child somewhere while perched on your favourite chair at home, in the wee hours when you’re most comfortable.

Charity First

We’ll come to the middlemen in a bit—the people who get you in touch with the NGOs. Before that, here’s a flavour for exactly what NGOs need of “virtual volunteers.”

Opportunities in virtual volunteering are usually spread through word of mouth and not via advertising or press releases: organisations simply don’t have enough money! It’s in that spirit that we’re here informing and encouraging you.

First off, you can write for the newsletters of NGOs and do design and layout work for them. If you have a flair for Web designing, you can build a Web site for your favourite helping-out organisation, or through research on the Internet, build content for the site, identify sources of funds, and rope in more volunteers. Those of artistic inclinations might consider creative designing of brochures, campaign posters, T-shirts, and presentations. Volunteers with a marketing background can help in online fund raising through marketing of in-house products produced by the NGO—for example, candles, greeting cards, and sweaters—which can be sold online. Coming to

more skilled areas, those with the skills can contribute to database management and translation. And remember, all this without leaving that favourite chair.

Now for the really difficult part. You don’t want to go running around looking for NGOs. And here’s where iVolunteer comes in: the organisation (www.ivolunteer.org.in) is an exchange platform where volunteers get connected with NGOs in India and abroad.

The Middlemen

Rahul Nainwal and Shalabh Sahai founded iVolunteer in 2001. They were then students at the Institute of Rural Management Anand (IRMA), Gujarat. They conceptualised the idea in order to create what iVolunteer is today—a platform where volunteers and voluntary organisations could meet. Right from the outset, then, iVolunteer had the aim of contributing to society in terms of giving time to and sharing skills with those in need. The organisation now has a network of over 300 credible non-profits spread across India, and is working on a variety of issues to create a database of opportunities for volunteers to get involved. iVolunteer mobilises volunteers and profiles them based upon their interest, skills, and availability. Its Volunteer Relationship team helps match volunteers to suitable opportunities.

iVolunteer also has programs that cater to those who don’t just want to help online: they

Organisations Where You Can E-Volunteer

Lend a hand if you can!

- ❑ VolunteerMatch Support has loads of opportunities in diverse fields like Advocacy and Human Rights, Crisis Support, Media and Broadcasting, and more. Find a field that suits you: www.volunteermatch.org/opportunities/virtual.jsp.
- ❑ Macdonald Youth Services has various opportunities in diverse fields. To find out about openings here, subscribe to their newsletter: www.mys.ca/volunteer.
- ❑ Daily Dump is a Bangalore-based organisation that runs a project on home composting so as to ensure homes manage their own organic waste at source. They need a visualiser for DTP work. bangalore@ivolunteer.org.in Ph.: 080-41466568
- ❑ Maithri Educational and Charitable Organization in Chennai deals with providing scholarships to physically-challenged students. They’re looking for volunteers to read out and record passages from textbooks for visually-impaired graduate students. chennai@ivolunteer.org.in Ph.: 044-42892791
- ❑ Abhyudaya, who help people reach a stage of self-sustenance by training them to

make textile products like *Dari*, bed-sheets, scarves, toys, etc. needs volunteers to assist in documentation and proposal development.

delhi@ivolunteer.org.in
Ph.: 011-26217460

- ❑ The South India Cell for Human Rights for Right Education and Monitoring (SICHREM) works for human rights and seeks to empower *Dalits*, tribal people, women, children, and minorities. They’re looking for someone who can write a four-page e-newsletter and update their Web site.

Ph.: 080-41466568
bangalore@ivolunteer.org.in

- ❑ Suyam Charitable Trust, which works in child and youth welfare programmes, needs volunteers to assist in documentation work, online fund raising activities, and media and corporate publicity.

chennai@ivolunteer.org.in
Ph.: 044-42892791

- ❑ GNAPE works in the field of nature conservation, preservation, and education through various research, documentation, and outreach programmes. They need volunteers to design their Web site and develop content.

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